PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Mercedes-Benz G-Class W463

1990–2018 · W463

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust, rust, rust**
  Handsome Motors lists the places to check: the roof around the sunroof, the metal under the tail-lights and rear door, every door hinge, the rear spring perches, the windscreen gasket, the mirror bases, the 'dog-leg' cavities inside the doors and every body seam. Autocar adds the inner wheel arches and the area around the rear bumper.

- [ ] **Test all three lockers**
  Engage centre, rear and front in order on loose ground and watch the indicators. Lockers that 'were never used' often don't work. Handsome Motors says to have the hydraulics flushed before chasing parts; vacuum leaks are the next suspect.

- [ ] **Drive it at 55–70 mph**
  Judder or shaking can mean a failing propshaft (Autocar budgets £1,500 or more). Harsh 2–3 shifts, flares or speed-sensor codes on the five-speed 722.6 point to old fluid or a failing conductor plate.

- [ ] **Early-2000s electrics**
  Handsome Motors says 2002–04 trucks suffer seat-motor, window-regulator and door-lock-actuator gremlins, along with transfer case motor and actuator faults, and that these improved each year until 2005–06. Test every switch.

- [ ] **A sagging headliner means water**
  Handsome Motors notes that 2002 US trucks have a hard fibreboard headliner while 2003-on trucks got a fabric one that is probably sagging by now. Autocar warns a sagging headliner can also mean water is getting in, so check the sunroof drains, the rear-door hinge seals and the fuse box area for damp.

- [ ] **Listen for a thump**
  Coil springs crack, especially in cold weather, and a loud thump over bumps is the sign. Autocar puts the fix at about £120 per corner.

- [ ] **Engine-specific weak spots**
  M113 (G 500, early G 55): harmonic balancer and viscous fan. M273 (G 550, 2009–15): starters every 50–60k miles, cam magnets and intake swirl flaps. M176 (2016–18): a failed crankcase-vent oil separator can cause rear-main and valve-cover leaks, with $3–5k in labour for the rear main seal (Handsome Motors). M157 G 63: inspect the cooling system and water pump.

- [ ] **Is it really an AMG?**
  Autocar warns about standard Gs converted to look like AMGs. Check the VIN and the factory data card, not the badges.

YEARS TO KNOW

2002–04	BEWARE	Early US trucks have the electrical gremlins: Handsome Motors lists seat motors and controls, window regulators and motors, door-lock actuators and transfer-case actuators.

		Expedition Portal owners say the same about 2002–03
2005–08	SWEET SPOT	The G 500 sweet spot. Handsome Motors says the early electrical faults were mostly gone by 2005–06; the US switch to the seven-speed came for MY2007

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Fuel return hose can crack and leak**
  2004–2005 G 55 AMG · NHTSA 05V378000
- ☐ **Incorrect SCN software coding**
  2003 G-Class · NHTSA 08V303000
- ☐ **Fuel line quick connectors not fully seated**
  2009 G 550 · NHTSA 09V453000
- ☐ **Front turn signals behind grille cover**
  2002–2010 G-Class · NHTSA 10V366000
- ☐ **Passenger airbag molding strip can come loose**
  2011 G 550 and G 55 AMG · NHTSA 12V380000
- ☐ **Steering coupling may be under-tightened**
  2013–2016 G 550 and G 63 AMG; 2016 G 65 AMG · NHTSA 17V250000
- ☐ **Inner door-release cable may break**
  2016 G 550 and G 63 AMG · NHTSA 17V178000
- ☐ **ESP fault with Distronic Plus engaged**
  2016–2017 G 550, G 63 AMG and G 65 AMG · NHTSA 17V713000
- ☐ **eCall date/time software fault**
  2013–2016 G 550 and G 63 AMG · NHTSA 19V787000
- ☐ **Incorrect software configuration after a service repair**
  2014 G 550 · NHTSA 22V168000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **VIN**
  US trucks from 2002 start WDC: a G 500 decodes as WDCYR49E and a 2003 G 55 AMG as WDCYR46E. Position 10 is the model year and position 11 is X for Graz. European-format chassis numbers carry the model code, such as WDB463228 on 500 GEs.
- ☐ **Europa International trucks**
  Europa federalised W463s from 1993 and issued US VINs as a small-volume manufacturer; Mercedes-Benz USA took over for MY2002. One BaT-sold Europa G 500's VIN fails NHTSA's standard decode, so get the import paperwork.
- ☐ **Fake AMGs**
  Autocar warns about Gs converted to look like AMGs. Check that the VIN and factory data card agree with the badges.
- ☐ **Factory data card**
  Mercedes-Benz Classic sells a digital data card with original option codes, paint and trim for most cars built 1986–2010 (AMG models excluded), for €130 with proof of ownership.
- ☐ **Lockers and traction aids**
  Every W463 has three locks, engaged in order: centre, rear, front. Trucks from the 2001–02 update also have ESP, Brake Assist and 4ETS; earlier ones rely on the lockers alone.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/g-class/w463/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks